



NATIONAL HIGH SCHOOL
ETHICS BOWL

NATIONAL CASE SET

2024-2025

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FROM THE EDITORIAL BOARD

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

The cases in this set were compiled for the 2024-2025 National High School Ethics Bowl Championship. Authored by a diverse group of community members, cases have been edited for content, clarity, and pedagogical focus by an Editorial Board composed of NHSEB's Executive Committee and Case Advisory Committee. More information on NHSEB personnel is available at nhseb.org/people.

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

The Discussion Questions provided by the Editorial Board in this set are designed to identify and get students thinking about the various moral issues and potential angles of consideration involved in each case. Discussion Questions do not (and are not designed to) exhaust the range of possible considerations on a given topic. Discussion Questions *will not* be used for officially-sanctioned NHSEB Regional Competitions or Divisional Playoffs. The Moderator Questions asked at each NHSEB-affiliated event will remain confidential until they are revealed in-match to preserve competitive fairness. For more information about competition procedures, please review NHSEB's [2024-2025 Rules Manual](#).

CASE REFERENCES AND RESEARCH

Cases designed for use in the National High School Ethics Bowl are often directly based on or otherwise inspired by real-world events, debates, etc. Throughout this case set, citations and references are included to provide further context on these events and issues where appropriate. Source materials cited in this document will only be identified once per case, though may be referenced more than once within a given case.

While NHSEB's rules do not actively discourage students from conducting outside research as they develop their arguments for competition, such research is *not* of primary importance when it comes to evaluation under the [NHSEB Scoring Criteria](#). A well-researched and well-cited argument is not necessarily an indication of a good normative argument that displays inventive thinking, deliberative reasoning, or other core features emphasized by the Ethics Bowl format. For more information on the role of research, official match and scoring procedures, and more, please review NHSEB's [2024-2025 Rules Manual](#).

Good Grief

The death of public figures, particularly those who represent certain social structures, can draw out a range of reactions from the online public, not all of which are solemn. On December 4th, 2024, Brian Thompson, the CEO of healthcare insurance provider UnitedHealthcare, was fatally shot in Midtown Manhattan. Shortly after, a TikTok video expressing the sentiment that no one should “snitch” on the shooter posted a generic photo of the Manhattan Bridge, overlaid with a meme of a man saying, “POV – everyone in Manhattan this morning: ‘oh, oh no, I ain’t seen nothing...matter of fact, I’m blind in my left eye and 43% blind in my right eye...A matter of fact, I can’t even see you, sir,’”¹ gained over 2 million views and 350k likes. Most comments also emphasized that they had no sympathy for police efforts to locate the shooter. Many, but not all, were intended to be humorous in tone, expressing sentiments such as: “thoughts and premiums”, “I actually didn’t see anything because my insurance doesn’t cover glasses”, “my empathy is out of network”, “do Aetna next”.

This is not the first time online posters have been less than grief-stricken over a well-reported death of someone representing a powerful social institution. When Queen Elizabeth II passed away in September 2022, one X user joked in response to another post asking for more decorous behavior: “Please be respectful when talking about the Queen. She was a head of state, a monarch, a mother to multiple pedophiles and most importantly a devoted cousin to her husband”². In June 2023, a submersible called the Titan imploded on an expedition to the wreckage of the Titanic with the submersible company founder, a technician, and three tourists who paid \$250,000 each for their tickets on board. One of the top liked comments on a TikTok video compiling 13 funny memes about the event set to a recorder badly playing a cover of “My Heart Will Go On”, soundtrack of the 1997 movie Titanic was: “They didn’t pay the extra 250k for a return ticket”³.

There are people who believe that this kind of reaction is never acceptable because it is highly disrespectful to speak ill of the dead. Regardless of what that person may have done in life or what they represent, they are no longer able to defend themselves from anything negative said about them, making it inappropriate to criticize them when they cannot respond. We also may owe the dead a certain level of respect, especially when they died under violent or otherwise extraordinary circumstances. Moreover, these people have family and friends who are already grieving their deaths. Seeing people online reacting this way to the passing of their loved one might exacerbate their emotional distress during a difficult time.

However, other people question why death makes people beyond reproach, especially if that person victimized others and upheld harmful social structures in life. Individuals might forfeit their right to respect after death if they, while alive, showed no respect for the lives of others. For the social media users posting such content, Brian Thompson represents corporate greed and healthcare inequality that causes deaths due to denied healthcare coverage. Queen Elizabeth II was the figurehead of a historically violent and colonizing empire. And the millionaires on the Titan submersible represent the wealth hoarding that contributes to worsening wealth disparity in the United States. The divided public reactions to these deaths sparked conversations about such topics as wealth disparity, corporate greed, healthcare inequity, and that may not have happened if internet users all adhered to the “don’t speak ill of the dead” principle.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Do we have an obligation to never speak ill of the dead, no matter what? Why, or why not?
2. Is it ever permissible to make light of or celebrate someone’s death? Why, or why not? When someone dies, is it appropriate to use their death to discuss social issues? If so, what is the most productive way to do so? If not, why not?

¹ [1] @abi333444, “POV – Everyone in Manhattan this morning”, TikTok, December 4, 2024, <https://www.tiktok.com/@abi333444/video/7444668442420055326>

² @roun_sa_ville, “Please be respectful when talking about the Queen. She was a head of state, a monarch, a mother to multiple pedophiles and most importantly a devoted cousin to her husband”, X, September 8, 2022, https://x.com/roun_sa_ville/status/1567853458581032960?s=20&t=SSUYHy438hfnlmaZt_qW5g

³ Abbey McNamara (@abbey.readss), “My screen time has doubled the past couple of days bc twitter is having a field day with the”, TikTok, June 21, 2023, <https://www.tiktok.com/@abbey.readss/photo/7247144436528958746>



Something Fishy This Way Comes

Amy is a waitress at a well-known seafood restaurant that is famous for its signature sea bass dish. Amy is proud of the restaurant's reputation and the bulk of her income depends on tips, so she always takes special care for the needs of customers. One evening, a customer orders the restaurant's famous sea bass but, after receiving it, complains to Amy that the fish doesn't taste right. They insist that the dish they received isn't sea bass at all. Concerned, Amy consults the chef, who admits the dish isn't sea bass but actually a cheaper fish—giant perch—but shrugs it off as a common way to keep costs down as few diners can detect the difference. In fact, Amy had just recently read a report that sea bass is mislabeled on menus nearly half of the time.¹

When Amy returns to the table, before she is able to say anything, the customer apologizes for the complaint, attributing it to simply not having had sea bass recently. Amy now faces a moral quandary. The customer has dropped the issue, but Amy knows the complaint was valid, and the restaurant is intentionally deceiving its patrons. On the one hand, Amy feels that honesty is essential. Customers deserve to know what they're eating, and the restaurant's intentional mislabeling of the fish is clearly violating that. Amy feels complicit in eroding trust with diners, even if they remain unaware of the deception.

On the other hand, Amy understands the practicalities of the situation. If exposed, this practice could damage the restaurant's reputation, alienate customers, and lead to legal consequences. Most customers don't know the difference, and this customer has dropped their complaint, so the risk of exposure seems low. Calling out the issue might, at best, cost her a big tip, and, at worst, jeopardize the job that she relies on for her livelihood. Amy wonders if revealing the truth to this table—or even addressing it with management—would be worth the potential fallout. What's more, the practice seems to be widespread in the restaurant world, and she fears that her anxiety over the dishonesty might be unfounded.

Amy's deliberations are complicated by the fact that she knows that sea bass is an overfished species and suffering significant population decline. Since people see fish like giant perch as “undesirable” it leads to wasted catch and depletes its population, while the sea bass population is overfished due to its popularity.² She thinks that her employer's mislabeling scheme could help address this two-fold problem. Amy wonders what, if anything, she should do?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is it okay to tell a lie if lying will have good consequences for everyone involved? Why or why not?
2. Do employees (such as waitstaff) have different obligations to their customers than businesses (such as restaurants) themselves do? Explain.

¹ <https://www.cnn.com/2019/03/07/health/fish-mislabeling-investigation-oceana/index.html#:~:text=There%27s%20something%2C%20well%2C%20fishy%20going,on%20the%20label%20or%20menu>
² <https://www.pbs.org/show/hope-in-the-water/>

Journalists Under Fire

When the United States invaded Iraq in 2003, the term “embedded journalism” entered the public lexicon. Journalists embedded with military units were granted unprecedented access to military operations, living and working alongside soldiers in the field, in the heart of the action, granting them a rare and intimate view of war. For many viewers and readers, this provided vivid, real-time accounts of military operations, bringing the realities of war into living rooms worldwide.

However, embedding journalists in close proximity to military operations came with restrictions. Contracts between media outlets and the military require journalists to adhere to strict rules, including refraining from publishing information that could compromise operational security. Some view this as necessary for protecting soldiers and missions, while other critics see it as censorship. Militaries are also aware unfiltered journalism has the potential to undermine public support for wars and may police journalists from that standpoint.

While the arrangement allowed journalists to report from the frontlines, critics argued that embedding raised serious conflicts of interest. When journalists depend on soldiers for food, transportation, sources, and survival, their reporting may lose impartiality. Embedded reporters may feel pressure, both explicit and implicit, to portray the side granting them access in a positive light, effectively turning them into unofficial extensions of the military's public relations efforts. They may present an overly sanitized view of war that omits critical perspectives such as civilians in conflict zones or deal with ambiguous responses from civilians. This concern is heightened by the fact that journalists cannot roam freely to gather alternative perspectives, as their movement is controlled by the military. Major developments can go unreported if the military was not present at the site and consequently no embedded journalists were either¹. Even when journalists believe they are presenting an objective reality, the filtered lens through which the military allows them to observe the world limits the information they can gather and share.

Supporters counter that embedded journalism provides a rare and unique window into the dimensions of war. They argue that embedded journalists provide crucial insights into the experiences of soldiers and the realities of war that might otherwise remain hidden, even with traditional independent news reporting. Embedded journalism enables reporters to bring to light the human side of war – capturing the bravery, fear, and camaraderie of soldiers, and interacting with isolated civilian populations. Restricting certain information may be a small price to pay to gain a deeper understanding of wartime experiences and updates. Furthermore, supporters note that restrictions on certain operational information were a necessary compromise to ensure safety and national security. These arrangements are often the only way to obtain stories from restricted and dangerous areas, ensuring that the public has some understanding of war beyond official press releases. Additionally, since many terrorist groups and non-state actors target journalists as potential hostages, it would seem embedding with a military unit is the safest way to gather information².

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How should journalists balance their duty to report the truth with contractual obligations to protect sensitive information?
2. Does the close relationship between embedded journalists and military units inherently compromise journalistic objectivity?
3. To what extent is it realistic to expect true objectivity from journalists?

¹ Cockburn, P. (2010, November 23). Embedded journalism: A distorted view of war. The Independent. <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/media/opinion/embedded-journalism-a-distorted-view-of-war-2141072.html>

² Ghosh, S. G. (2021, September 27). A contemporary deep-dive into embedded journalism. The Pangean. <https://thepangean.com/A-Contemporary-Deep-Dive-Into-Embedded-Journalism>



Good Luck Babe

Chappell Roan (a.k.a. Kayleigh Rose Amstutz), a 27-year-old singer-songwriter, rose to global stardom in just a few months. After the breakout success of her album and single "Good Luck, Babe!" in 2024, she transitioned from performing for intimate crowds to headlining major venues.

However, this rapid ascent came at a cost. Roan voiced concerns about fans invading her personal life in a TikTok post, sharing her discomfort with intrusive fan behavior (ex. going so far as to stalk her family) and asserting her right to set boundaries despite her fame. According to Roan, privacy was important to her even before her rise to stardom; she'd adopted a stage name to separate her personal and public personas. In a follow-up post, Roan pushed back against the notion that harassment is an inevitable side effect of commercial success, labeling such expectations as "weird." However, Roan also acknowledged the difficulty of navigating the parasocial relationships formed by fans and the expectations they have of her as a performer: "I don't really know what to do, because I don't know any artist who has escaped the expectations of people that think they know the artist."¹

In the fall, Roan was scheduled to headline the All Things Go music festival. Yet, just one day before her performance, she announced via Instagram that she was unable to perform. "Things have gotten overwhelming over the past few weeks, and I am really feeling it," she wrote. "I feel pressures to prioritize a lot of things right now, and I need a few days to prioritize my health. I want to be present when I perform and give the best shows possible. Thank you for understanding."²

While Roan's plea for privacy gained support from some fans, others expressed frustration. Thousands of fans had bought tickets, made travel arrangements, and eagerly anticipated her performance. Many argue that public scrutiny is inevitable for celebrities, claiming that a diminished right to privacy is a natural consequence of choosing a life in the spotlight. This raises the question: in a world where social media has intensified parasocial relationships—blurring the lines between public persona and private life—what should aspiring celebrities expect to have to give up for fame?

Additionally, many commenters on this issue blame the rise of social media for further complicating the fan-celebrity dynamic, as it has provided fans with more direct access to celebrities and has fostered expectations of constant interaction. However, as Roan and others note, this often blurs the line between admiration and entitlement, creating a culture where fans feel a sense of "ownership" over a star's life.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Should celebrities expect to sacrifice their right to privacy, or is it reasonable for them to set these boundaries and demand respect for their personal lives, despite their public status?
2. How does a celebrity's obligation to the public compare to the obligations of people working in other industries?
3. Did Roan do something wrong by cancelling her festival show? Do fans have a right to be upset?
4. Where is the line between being a fan of a celebrity and violating their privacy rights? What kinds of activities should be public or private?

¹ <https://www.washingtonpost.com/style/of-interest/2024/08/26/chappell-roan-fan-behavior-tiktok-privacy/>

² <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/09/27/arts/music/chappell-roan-cancels-festival.html#:~:text=In%20a%20statement%20posted%20on,to%20perform%2C%E2%80%9D%20Roan%20said>

To Repair Or Replace?

NASA's flagship astrophysics missions have always been at the forefront of human ingenuity, but they also bring ethical challenges about how to balance risk, cost, and sustainability. The Hubble Space Telescope, for instance, was designed to be repairable through the course of its life, allowing astronauts to fix early design flaws and extend its functionality through five servicing missions. These efforts saved Hubble and maximized the value of the initial investment, enabling decades of groundbreaking science.

In contrast, the James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) was launched with no provisions for servicing—despite 344 single-point failures, any one of which could have doomed the mission. While JWST's success has been extraordinary, it was a high-stakes gamble, with no backup if something went wrong.

NASA now faces this dilemma anew as it plans its next flagship mission, the Habitable Worlds Observatory (HWO). Unlike Hubble, HWO will be stationed far beyond the reach of astronauts. The question is whether to make HWO serviceable, potentially by designing it to accommodate future robotic repairs or upgrades¹, or to launch the mission with the knowledge that it cannot be repaired.

Critics of serviceability believe the focus should remain on launching HWO as soon as possible, maximizing its initial capabilities. Adding serviceability to HWO would increase the mission's complexity and cost. Robotic servicing technology, while promising, is still in development, and its reliability for missions like HWO remains uncertain. Including this capability in HWO's design could delay its launch, potentially postponing groundbreaking discoveries that the telescope might enable. They argue that the success of JWST proves it's possible to build a high-performing telescope without the added complexity and expense of repairability. For them, the immediate opportunity for groundbreaking discoveries outweighs uncertain benefits decades down the line.

On the other hand, proponents of serviceability contend that failing to plan for repairs or upgrades is shortsighted. They argue that space exploration is inherently unpredictable and that designing HWO to be serviceable would ensure its scientific productivity for decades, even if unexpected issues arise and extend the telescope's useful life. Serviceability could also allow future generations of researchers to benefit from advances in technology, aligning with a more sustainable and forward-thinking approach to space exploration.

There is significant good in scientific discovery, but these missions are expensive and funding for NASA comes from a federal budget. Amid recent questions about how federal funds should be spent, decisions that affect both the cost and longevity of projects like HWO become more pressing.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Should NASA prioritize designing HWO with robotic servicing capabilities, even if it increases costs and delays? Why or why not?
2. Do government programs like NASA have an ethical obligation to design "serviceable" products, given their reliance on public funds? How might the obligations of privately funded organizations, like SpaceX, be different?
3. Is it ethically justifiable to replace technology instead of repairing it based solely on cost and convenience? Are our obligations different in our personal lives?
4. What value might come from newly building and replacing technology instead of repairing it?

¹ <https://science.nasa.gov/astrophysics/programs/habitable-worlds-observatory/>

Art-Appropriate

Sophia, a high school senior, visits an art fair hosting artists from diverse backgrounds and art that represents a wide range of cultures. She stumbles upon a captivating painting depicting a Native American burial site. The artwork is rich with symbolism, hinting at themes of life after death, spirituality, and the interconnectedness of all living things—concepts that resonate with Sophia's own musings about humanity and existence.

Enthralled by the painting's beauty and the themes it embodies, Sophia decides to purchase it to hang in her room. She believes the piece not only enhances her personal space but also serves as a profound reminder of the shared human experiences across different cultures.

However, when Sophia shares a photo of the painting on social media, the responses are mixed. Some friends admire her taste, while others raise concerns. One comment reads, "Is it appropriate to display sacred symbols from a culture that isn't yours?" Another friend adds, "Art is universal, and appreciating it is a way of honoring the culture. How else are we supposed to learn?"

Sophia hadn't considered that the burial site might hold significant spiritual importance exclusive to Native American communities. She begins to wonder if her admiration crosses into appropriation. Determined to understand the implications, she researches the origins of the painting and the artist. She learns that the artist is not of Native American descent but was inspired by a visit to historical sites in the Southwest. This discovery causes her to raise questions about whether it was appropriate for the artist to depict this in the first place and whether her purchase is contributing to a commodification of cultural traditions.

Sophia contemplates her next steps; what if anything should she do?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is Sophia's decision to purchase and display the painting an act of cultural appreciation or cultural appropriation?
2. What factors determine whether engaging with another culture's art is respectful or appropriative?
3. Does an artist's lack of heritage affect the ethical considerations when creating, selling, or buying art from a specific culture?
4. What is the role of intent versus impact when it comes to cultural appropriation in art?

Clean Slate, Fresh Start

In the movie “Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind”, Lacuna, Inc. offers a revolutionary service: the selective erasure of painful or unwanted memories. The film centers on Joel and Clementine, a former couple whose intense relationship was marked by both excitement and chaos. After their breakup leaves them heartbroken, they each independently decide to undergo Lacuna's procedure, erasing all memories of each other and their tumultuous relationship. The process takes place while they sleep, ensuring they wake up with no recollection of their decision to erase such a significant part of their lives, effectively starting with a “clean slate.” Though *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* is only a movie, studies on animals have shown that selective memory erasure is theoretically possible¹ and there are countless ways it might be applied in humans.

Proponents of selective memory erasure argue that this technology could offer tremendous relief to individuals who are burdened by memories that hinder their ability to live normally. In cases of PTSD, for instance, traumatic memories can continue to affect a person's mental and emotional well-being long after the event has passed. The constant flashbacks, anxiety, and emotional distress make it difficult for them to function in daily life, maintain relationships, or excel in their careers. Advocates believe that by erasing these debilitating memories, individuals can regain control over their lives and find peace, finally freed from the shadows of their past.

However, there are serious concerns about the ethical and psychological implications of the procedure if it were to develop for use in humans. Painful memories, though difficult to bear, are an integral part of personal growth and emotional resilience. The experiences, both good and bad, that we carry with us shape our identities and inform our values, decisions, and future actions. By removing painful memories, individuals may lose essential life lessons or parts of their character that contribute to their emotional maturity. Erasing painful memories could diminish a person's capacity for self-awareness, limiting their ability to learn from past mistakes or develop coping mechanisms for future challenges.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Can individuals experiencing extreme emotional distress give informed consent for a procedure like selective memory erasure?
2. How does a procedure like this one compare to other, more conventional, methods of emotional relief or escape?
3. Do painful memories have value? What are the benefits of losing them? What are the benefits of keeping them?

¹ <https://www.cuimc.columbia.edu/news/select-memories-can-be-erased-leaving-others-intact>

Brew-HaHa Bifurcation

Brew Haven is a popular student-run coffee shop in the bustling college town of Academia. Known for its commitment to fair trade and sustainable practices, the shop has served as a rallying point for environmental activism around campus and in the broader community.

While working one day, Vish and Anya, two student workers, stumbled upon documents showing that work-study and regular student employees at Brew Haven were being paid different hourly wages. Work-study is a federal program that provides undergraduate students who qualify for need-based income with part-time jobs and subsidizes the wages employers pay. Because the pay of work-study students is subsidized, work-study employees at Brew Haven are paid more than other student workers. Brew Haven contributes the same amount—\$12 per hour—to the pay of all its employees, but work-study employees receive an additional \$5 per hour due to the subsidy. This pay disparity does not violate any official policies. A university note at the bottom of the documents permits employers to choose whether or not they want to increase the wage for regular student employees to align with the work-study rate. Vish and Anya recognized that the decision to not increase the non-work study wages may be due to Brew Haven's difficulties making rent, as the shop's rent had recently doubled.

Vish and Anya initially reported these documents through the proper internal channels but found no relief. As a regular student employee, Vish wants to leak the information. He believes that the community deserves to know about Brew Haven's employee pay disparity. He also wants to ensure that he is compensated fairly for his work, despite not needing the money. For Vish, it is about the principle of equal pay, irrespective of financial situation.

Anya, a work-study student, does not want to expose Brew Haven. She is worried that if she leaks the documents Brew Haven will be unable to make rent, go out of business and cause her to lose her job. The coffee shop is her only source of income, and although she could seek employment elsewhere, this job is one of the few that is close to campus and able to accommodate her busy class schedule.

Beyond her financial concerns, Anya is also worried about the larger impact of damaging Brew Haven's reputation. Before Brew Haven's establishment, many stores in Academia engaged in unsustainable practices and the larger community was generally not environmentally conscious. Since Brew Haven committed itself to being a zero-waste store, however, the broader community has changed for the better. There have been widespread efforts to be more environmentally conscious, and environmental activism and awareness have particularly taken off.

Anya truly believes in the ability of Brew Haven to continue to have a positive impact on the community, as beyond just promoting environmentally conscious practices, Brew Haven has been one of the longest-standing student employers in town. Though she recognizes that it is unfair for students like Vish to be underpaid, she is conflicted that leaking the documents could also jeopardize a large source of current and future student employment.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is there anything wrong with paying workers who have similar work experiences different rates for the same job? Under what circumstances might such pay disparity be reasonable?
2. Do workers have a right to pay transparency? Why or why not?
3. Considering Vish's desire for equal pay and Anya's concern for the financial stability of Brew Haven and its impact on the community, how can we relate these individual moral concerns with the responsibilities of business institutions?

Assessing Silence

In Ms. Lopez's high school English class, students are regularly graded on how well they participate in discussions, especially how they articulate arguments and present ideas. Recently, the school district has decided to formally assess the listening side of discussion. The idea is to ensure that students aren't just good speakers but that they also listen well to others. Under this new policy, students will be graded on how well they listen to their peers—assessment criteria will include demonstrating understanding, asking relevant follow-up questions, and showing empathy for different perspectives.

However, the new assessment method is controversial. While it is generally accepted that listening is important, assessing it is challenging. Some students, like Emma, feel anxious about being graded on something that happens internally. She worries that her listening skills aren't easily observable, especially since she prefers to reflect silently rather than ask follow-up questions or react visibly during discussions. Emma feels that being assessed on listening is unfair because it's harder to measure than speaking. Who gets to decide if she's really listening?

Meanwhile, Jordan, a more outspoken student, argues that listening should have been taken seriously all along. He believes that many of his classmates don't listen to perspectives they find uncomfortable and that assessing listening would force them to confront this. Jordan feels that ethical listening, which involves actively engaging with perspectives different from one's own, should be part of the curriculum. However, he also acknowledges that the standards don't specify what is important to listen to. Should every perspective get equal weight? Should students be required to listen with the same level of attention to controversial or even harmful viewpoints? Who decides which perspectives deserve their attention?

Some teachers argue that requiring students to listen is important for teaching them to engage with marginalized voices, practicing empathy, and instilling a sense of community responsibility. Others worry about interpreting a student's intent and values; that making these dimensions explicit could open the door to subjective grading and unfair expectations, especially if students are required to listen respectfully to ideas they find offensive or ethically troubling.

As the district moves forward with implementing listening assessments, students, parents, and teachers alike are left to grapple with whether listening should be graded, how it can be fairly assessed, and what the moral responsibilities of listening are in a diverse classroom.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is it fair to assess students on listening, a skill that happens largely internally? How can it be measured without becoming too subjective?
2. Should students be graded on the ethical dimensions of listening, such as showing empathy or engaging with diverse perspectives, even if they disagree with what is being said? Are there limits to this?
3. Who should decide what's important to listen to in a classroom setting? Should all perspectives be listened to equally, or should some voices be given more weight? How do we navigate this fairly?
4. If listening assessments privilege certain types of students, such as those who are more outwardly engaged, over quieter or more reflective students, is this unfair?

No Contact

Growing up, Emma was always close with her parents. They were loving and supportive, and did everything that they could to prepare her for a successful, independent adult life. But as Emma got older, she started to notice that she disagreed more and more with her parents. Their interactions began to feel tense. She would invariably dread talking to her parents, and doing so would always leave her in a bad mood.

Now in her early twenties, Emma is thinking about going “no contact” with her parents. She has tried to talk to them about the things that they do to upset her, such as forcing political discussions that they know will make her uncomfortable, or making unwanted comments about her life decisions and appearance. Nothing has changed. Nor have they respected her requests that they stop making unwanted comments about her lifestyle and appearance. She has given up hope that her parents will start treating her differently, and she thinks that her interactions with her parents are taking a toll on her mental health.

Emma’s partner, Sam, supports Emma’s choice to distance herself from her parents. Sam thinks that no one should have to spend time around people who are openly disrespectful to them. Especially since Emma has already tried working with her parents to improve their relationship, and they have not listened to her, Sam thinks that Emma is more than justified in going no contact.

Emma’s brother, Mikey, disagrees. While Mikey does not approve of his parents’ treatment of Emma, he thinks that it is best for adult children to stay in touch with their parents. For one thing, he thinks that Emma should be more grateful for all of the work their parents put into raising them. Even Emma sees that their parents gave them a good childhood and did a lot to contribute to their becoming happy, well-adjusted adults. Mikey thinks that, in light of this, Emma owes it to her parents to maintain their relationship. He also thinks that Emma should have more patience with the generational differences at play. Their parents grew up in a different time and place than he and Emma did. They are not bad people, just people whose views are a little behind the times. Mikey thinks of this as a normal part of getting older – he expects that he and Emma will be similarly behind in a few decades. Lastly, he thinks that it is bad for adult children to cut out their parents because doing so contributes to placing older and younger people in echo chambers where their views are only reinforced and never challenged. Family seems to him like a valuable source of intergenerational engagement that shouldn’t be so easily discarded. It might be unpleasant to disagree about important issues, but isn’t it also a way for both Emma and her parents to learn from one another?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What do adult children owe to their parents?
2. Is it ever acceptable for an adult to go “no contact” with their parents? Does an adult need a good reason to go “no contact”? What reasons for doing that would count as good reasons?
3. Are families an important part of resisting the creation of political echo chambers? Are adult children obligated to stay in contact with their parents for this reason?
4. Do we have any obligations to our family that we don’t have to other relationships?

See Spot Clone

Samara's family dog, Biscuit, passed away a few months after she moved out of her parents' home to go to college. She was devastated, but her father, who took on the primary responsibility of caring for the animal, was even more so. She knew that her parents would be looking for a new dog, but when she returned home on a school break she was surprised to see a pair of puppies who both look almost identical to Biscuit in every way.

Her parents had found a company called ViaGen, which, for a fee, was able to clone Biscuit using skin cells harvested at the time of his death. Samara is conflicted. Part of her is glad to see that her father has been able to move past the grief of losing their dog, but another part of her is worried that her parents have been taken advantage of. The procedure was incredibly expensive, and the two dogs may *look* like Biscuit, but they have very different personalities. Samara supposes that this is due to the difference in the puppies' upbringing, but she worries that her parents had been under the impression that their new dog would be a copy of Biscuit in every way, including behavior¹.

Animal cloning has been available since the 90s. It has been used to create more productive livestock animals, help scientists study diseases, and restore endangered populations². Cloning a pet dog, though, can cost upwards of 50,000 dollars and some critics worry that the procedure is frivolous. This is especially true when there are so many shelter animals in need of homes that could be adopted instead. To successfully clone an animal, eggs must be harvested from one dog and then implanted into another additional animal. From start to finish, two dogs are operated on in order to produce a clone, and many believe that there is something wrong with the lives of these "unseen" animals being used as a means to an end.

Having a pet that reminds people of the animals that they lost might be a good thing. But when the cloned pet retains none of the same memories as the original, will be born with a different personality, and cost significantly more than a pet obtained from any other source, some people wonder where the benefit actually lies. Still though, the pet owners who have purchased cloned animals do report being happy with their decision and often feel a stronger connection to their new animals.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is there a moral difference between cloning a pet who has died and cloning a human relative or friend who has died? Why or why not?
2. Is the financial cost of cloning a pet unconscionable in a way that the cost of other expensive luxuries, like high-end cars, is not?
3. Whose responsibility is it to mind the ethical considerations associated with cloning pets? Is it the companies that provide this service? The pet owners who seek it out? the government? Someone else?
4. How might one compare the moral weight between cloning a pet, buying from a breeder, or adopting from a shelter?

¹ <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2024/07/01/would-you-clone-your-dog>

² <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/animal-news/scientists-clone-first-u-s-endangered-species-n1258310>

Dotty Identification

Every time you print a document, your printer secretly leaves behind a trail of invisible dots—a high-tech fingerprint that could trace the page directly back to you¹.

These nearly invisible yellow dots, which encode information such as the printer's serial number and the date and time of printing, are essential tools for law enforcement. They assist in combating counterfeiting and forgery by enabling authorities to trace printed materials back to their source. This capability is particularly vital in preventing the production of counterfeit currency and fraudulent documents, thereby upholding economic stability and legal integrity. Additionally, in cases involving the dissemination of sensitive or classified information, tracking dots can help identify unauthorized disclosures and trace them back to their source.

Still, there are significant concerns here regarding privacy and consent. The covert nature of these tracking mechanisms means that most printer users are unaware of their existence, leading to an erosion of personal privacy. Every printed document carries potentially traceable information, which, if misused, could lead to unwarranted surveillance or the targeting of individuals, especially in regimes with poor human rights records. The European Union has expressed concerns that such practices may violate human rights, emphasizing the need for transparency and user consent².

Furthermore, the potential for abuse by unauthorized parties poses a significant risk. If the encoding schemes are deciphered, individuals with malicious intent could track or impersonate others, leading to identity theft or unwarranted tracking.

Even if these dots are used to keep the public safe, the lack of transparency from manufacturers about the presence and function of these tracking dots exacerbates concerns around consent, as consumers are left uninformed and unable to make conscious choices about their privacy.³

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Should manufacturers be required to disclose the presence of tracking mechanisms in their devices?
2. Is it ever possible to achieve a true balance between national security interests and individual privacy rights?
3. What regulatory frameworks should exist to oversee the use of technology such as this? Are there any ethical concerns about a regulatory framework of this kind?
4. To what extent and how should companies be expected to resist demands from governments that may compromise individual rights?

¹ <https://www.bbc.com/future/article/20170607-why-printers-add-secret-tracking-dots>

² <https://eff.org/deeplinks/2008/02/eu-printer-tracking-dots-may-violate-human-rights>

³ <https://www.eff.org/wp/investigating-machine-identification-code-technology-color-laser-printers>

A Thin Line

Ozempic and Wegovy, brand names for the drug semaglutide, were initially developed to treat type 2 diabetes. They help control blood sugar levels and reduce the risk of cardiovascular events like heart attacks and strokes. However, a notable side effect—rapid weight loss—has led to their increasing cosmetic use for managing body weight.

As of 2023, these drugs are approved for use in children as young as 12 and are increasingly being used by teenagers for weight management.¹ These developments have caused some to worry that the widespread availability of semaglutide for teenagers might exacerbate toxic beauty standards. In a society already saturated with messages glorifying thinness, offering a medical route for rapid weight loss could reinforce harmful ideas about body image. Adolescents are particularly vulnerable to societal pressures, and normalizing the use of weight loss drugs among teens may further entrench beliefs that thinness somehow equates to worthiness, health, wealth, or status. Critics worry that such drugs might shift focus away from promoting overall well-being and self-acceptance toward achieving an idealized body type. They argue that instead of treating a medical condition as it's intended, semaglutide could become a tool for meeting societal expectations, with potential psychological consequences for teenagers who feel pressured to conform. Additionally, the cost of semaglutide is prohibitive for many families, raising issues of equity. If only those with financial resources can access the drug, its availability may deepen existing disparities, privileging wealthier teens while leaving others without comparable options for weight management.

On the other hand, it's important to recognize the importance of personal autonomy. Advocates for continued access to the drug point out that individuals, regardless of age, should have the right to make choices about their bodies, particularly if those choices improve their self-esteem or mental health. For teenagers struggling with body image or bullying related to weight, access to semaglutide might provide a path to confidence and a better quality of life. It is also important to consider that, for some teens, losing weight is not only about self-esteem but also about access to public space and medical care. Weight stigma and discrimination have well-documented negative health consequences.² Proponents contend that denying access to a drug that could significantly improve both physical and mental health might be paternalistic and dismissive of individual needs. Besides, the drug ought to be available for its original intended purpose, treating type-2 diabetes, and restricting access based on how it might be abused could put lives at risk.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is there anything wrong with wanting your body to look a certain way? Does a person's reason for desiring a certain look matter?
2. Are there important moral differences between prescribing weight loss drugs to adults, teenagers, and children?
3. Is making weight loss easier and more accessible a good response to the problems of weight stigma and anti-fat bias?
4. Do governments or drug companies have any responsibility to ensure that people have access to new drugs that could be beneficial to their health?

¹ <https://www.nbcnews.com/health/kids-health/weight-loss-drugs-teens-ozempic-wegovy-kids-rcna139687>

² <https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/obesity-discrimination-in-healthcare#summary>

Corrupted Contributions

Charles and William run a non-profit organization called Demos. Demos promotes public philosophy and outreach, aiming to cultivate ethical thinking and civic virtue among a general audience. Demos hosts routine public lectures, funds reading groups open to everyone, and runs an ethics club at a nearby college. Most notably, it facilitates regular seminars at high schools, where students engage deeply with ethical issues and develop intellectual virtues. Phobos BioSolutions, a pharmaceutical company, approaches Charles and William with a hefty donation offer. In return, Demos would only need to include a short acknowledgement—'Demos is funded with a generous donation from Phobos BioSolutions'—in its documents, promotional materials, and website. However, Phobos BioSolutions has a deeply tarnished reputation. The company was recently found to be engaged in several unethical practices: promoting drugs for unapproved uses, failing to report safety data, and offering illegal kickbacks to physicians. It is widely seen as a profit-driven and corrupt organization.

William thinks Demos should accept the money. Demos does great work in their local community, and the extra funds from Phobos BioSolutions could allow them to expand their programs into many more high schools, maybe even turning their local organization into a national one. Furthermore, William points out that if Demos refuses the donation, another organization—one with fewer ethical concerns—might accept it instead. Not only will this donation help them do good in the immediate future, it will also protect against giving bad organizations more funding.

However, Charles disagrees with William. He strongly believes that Demos should not accept the money from Phobos BioSolutions. He believes it sends the wrong message to the communities Demos serves. Because they will be forced to put the pharmaceutical organizations name on their materials, Charles worries this will constitute a tacit support of the company, one that legitimizes their image. Phobos BioSolutions is seen as a thoroughly corrupt company, and Demos, especially because of their high social standing and charitable work, should not rehabilitate their reputation, Charles thinks. He argues that such associations could erode the public's trust in Demos and undermine their mission to promote ethical thinking. Finally, he worries that there is something inherently troubling about associating with such a corrupt organization, regardless of the public's perception of this relationship.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How should a non-profit organization like Demos balance its mission to promote ethics with the practical need for funding?
2. In what ways does the source of funding affect the ethical integrity of an organization?
3. Does accepting a donation from a person or organization imply endorsement of that person or organization's actions or values? Why or why not?
4. Could their decision regarding the donation make Demos complicit in how unethical organizations gain influence elsewhere? Why or why not?

To Live Forever?

Bryan Johnson, a 47-year-old entrepreneur, has devoted his life to an experiment he calls “Project Blueprint.” The goal of Project Blueprint is to delay aging and possibly achieve immortality. His daily regimen includes over 100 supplements, a calorie-restricted vegan diet, intensive exercise, and precise monitoring of nearly every bodily function. With a motto of “Don’t Die,” Johnson sees himself as a pioneer in the quest to make death optional. Beyond his personal goals, he markets expensive products to his social media followers, further popularizing his vision.¹

Johnson’s approach is part of a broader trend in longevity research, with some scientists suggesting that extending human lifespan—even doubling it—might soon be possible. Proponents argue that such advancements could reduce suffering, allowing people to live longer, healthier lives. Extended lifespans might also offer individuals more time to grow, learn, and contribute meaningfully to society.

However, the project of extending the lifespan of the longest-lived humans has its critics. Twentieth-century philosopher Bernard Williams argued that immortality might lead to existential boredom, as people exhaust their desires and ambitions. Others worry about fairness—would only the wealthiest, like Johnson, afford immortality, deepening existing inequalities? Immortal elites could dominate politics, economics, and culture, entrenching power indefinitely.

Further concerns include resource use and social stagnation. A world filled with immortals might strain the planet’s already limited resources, while eliminating generational turnover could stifle innovation and adaptation. Death, some argue, plays a crucial role in shaping how we value life. Without it, would life lose its meaning and urgency?

While Johnson may never achieve his goal, his project raises timeless ethical questions: Should humanity aim to defeat death, or does mortality give life its significance? What costs—social, environmental, or existential—are we willing to accept in pursuit of this goal?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Is the pursuit of immortality an ethical goal, or does it risk causing harm to individuals or society?
2. How might living forever change our understanding of what makes life meaningful?
3. Should society invest in life-extension technologies, or focus on improving the quality of life for everyone?
4. Could removing death from human existence have unintended social or environmental consequences?

¹ <https://www.netflix.com/tudum/articles/dont-die-man-who-wants-to-live-forever>



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